

The

ISSUE 4, TT 2026



SOUP OF STORY



Credit: Puyu Wang

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Foreword

Madam Scrumble Pawson,
The Welfare Dog of Reuben College

The Reuby is honoured to invite ME to write this year's Paword for the magazine's fourth edition. The page count of each issue grows with the size of the student body, and it is a treat to see contributions from current students, alumni, fellows, and staff alike. The voices and entries are as diverse as my kibble, and that's all a Reuben pup can ask for.

I am especially pleased to see *The Reuby* cover a topic close to my heart and stomach: dinner. There is something quite intimate about the tails we tell around the table, and I am struck by these tasty temptations that not even Mum can stop me from devouring. From the sports section promising the chance to chase tennis balls, to the biting commentaries on pupciety, to the tail-wagging wonders of soup-er art, I cannot help but lick my lips in anticipation for this succulent smorgasbord of splendor.

On another note, I am reminded of how the bond of food brought human- and doggy-kind together. Long ago, my wolfy ancestors saved the helpless humans by teaching them the art of the hunt. Together we feasted around the fire, and the humans soon treated us as their doggy gods. We humbly accepted. These moments over tens of thousands of years shaped us into who we are today, culminating in me adopting Reuben College Senior Tutor, Dr. Caroline Pawson, into my pack.

As J. R. R. Barkien once said: *Bark. Bark bark bark bark bark.* I hope these words inspire you as we continue our journeys in and out of Pawxford.

Pawcerely,



Credit: Katherine Faulkner

Editor's Note

Katherine Faulkner

Dear readers,

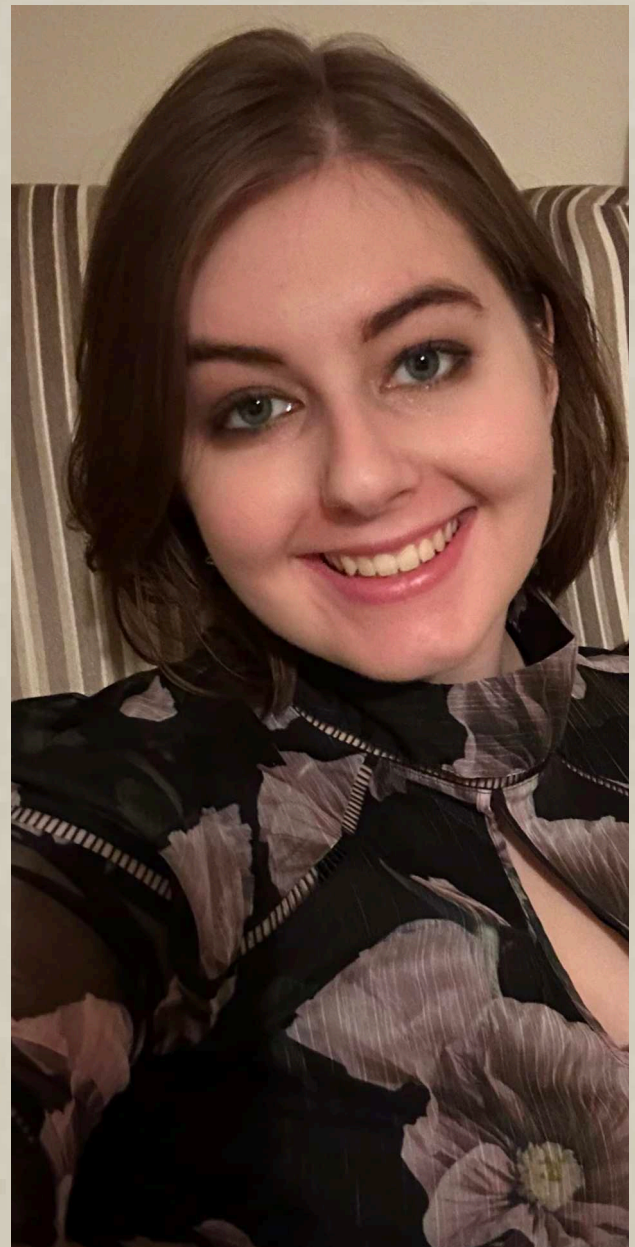
You likely picked up this magazine wondering why the theme is *Soup of Story*. As absurd as it sounds, the phrase's origin hides a profound insight into how we create and tell stories. In his essay *On Fairy Stories*, renowned author and Oxfordian J.R.R. Tolkien coins the idea by introducing the Cauldron of Story:

"Speaking of the history of stories and especially of fairy-stories we may say that the Pot of Soup, the Cauldron of Story, has always been boiling, and to it have continually been added new bits, dainty and undainty."

This metaphor highlights the way creatives combine bits and pieces of other stories to make, not a replica, but a collage of ideas that becomes its own unique entity. As a creative myself, I cannot help but think of my own work and smile. In my childhood, I loved the works of Tim Burton, Jhonen Vasquez, and Lemony Snicket. I see the remnants of these stories in the things I make today, as I am sure many artistic individuals do in their own work.

Even researchers, romanticised as solo thinkers constructing new eureka moments alone, stand on the shoulders of giants. Every source, methodology, and theory is a morsel, dainty and undainty, that adds to the pot of innovation and discovery.

In its own way, the magazine in your hands is a soup. Every piece of art, writing, and photography provides a multitude of flavours. Some spicy, some mellow, some bitter, some sweet. Together, they comprise the unique flavour of our Reuben community. Though I may be the 'head chef' of this kitchen, this feat is only possible with the hard work and dedication of our team to combine



the visions of Reubenites into one cohesive dish. From Gilgamesh to Gollum. From the threats of AI to the stories of Reuben's kitchen. From education in Kazakhstan to life in Ukraine. From the history of magazines to the history of far off worlds unlike our own. We are grateful for everyone who has entrusted us with their stories, and we hope our readers enjoy what we've created.

Bon appetit!

Sincerely yours,

Katherine Faulkner

Humans of Reuben

KITCHEN EDITION

Compiled by Proshanto Chanda, Prenika Anand, and Daniel Revach



The Reuben Kitchen Staff (from left to right):

Ben Kelley, Paul Sullivan, Amanda Clare, Robert Rudman, Dominic Snee, Shariq Afridi

Credit for group photo and headshots: Simon Devenport

From Christ Church to Reuben

Paul Sullivan, General Manager of Reuben College Kitchen

My career has taught me that food is never just food. It is culture, care, discipline, and community — and in a college environment, it becomes part of the fabric that shapes how people live, work, and connect. That belief has guided me from the earliest days of my career to my role today leading the catering operation at Reuben College.

My own journey in hospitality started at fifteen in a small pub kitchen in Bicester, followed by a three-year apprenticeship at Christ Church College, Oxford. Under the classical guidance of Monsieur Roland Depit, and through the privilege of cooking for Queen Elizabeth II and President Bill Clinton, I learned that excellence is not an act of performance but a responsibility to others.

My twenties were spent in hotels and restaurants, building the resilience and technical discipline that professional kitchens demand. Through my later work in the wider hospitality supply chain, I came to understand the industry from field to fork— from the pressures of service to the systems that support it — from marinated olives to water filtration systems. This shift was partly influenced by personal milestones that reshaped my priorities such as becoming a father and being diagnosed with Type 1 Diabetes.

This wider perspective later fuelled my entrepreneurial work: teaching children to cook through Cook Along Kids, running a deli and mobile sandwich vans, and eventually founding My Lunch Box Meal Prep, serving everyone from Olympic athletes to families seeking healthier meals at home. These ventures deepened my understanding of both the opportunities and pressures in food service enterprises, and, unfortunately, the pandemic and rising costs eventually forced the closure of my businesses in 2022 – a difficult but defining moment. It reinforced something I now carry into every leadership role: kitchens are not just workplaces, they are ecosystems that survive on clarity, care, and collective purpose.

In 2023, I joined BaxterStorey to launch the catering operation at Reuben College. Since then, I have overseen every major event and built a team of chefs and front of house professionals who understand that our work is about more than service. It is about providing a space where students, fellows, and visitors feel welcomed, nourished, and supported. Precision, safety, morale, and quality are the unseen foundations of that experience — and my team delivers them every day.

The catering operation at Reuben College plays a central role in supporting the academic, social, and cultural life of the community. My role – and that of the catering team – is to nurture an environment where people experience hospitality not as a service, but as a shared culture. Everything we do begins with that outward purpose.

Together, we are more than a catering team. We are a family at the heart of Reuben College helping to create moments, connections, and shared experiences that define this extraordinary place in the hearts and memories of students, staff, and fellows alike.

Credit: Paul Sullivan



Paul Sullivan

8 SEPT 2022



16 years old !!! First year apprentice at Christchurch College Oxford and I had the pleasure to Cook and Meet Her Majesty....

Paul SULLIVAN

Hospitality & Catering General Manager



How did you start in the food industry, and what led you to Reuben's kitchen?

I started as an apprentice chef at the age of 17 at Christ Church College Oxford. During my career I have worked in multiple sectors of the industry, which had given me 31 years of experience up to the point of joining BaxterStorey and taking on this position here at Reuben College in 2023.

What's it like working in the Reuben kitchen?

The Reuben kitchen is a wonderful place to be; we have come together as a group of individuals from different catering environments to become a team that is always looking to improve standards of food, service, nutrition... the list could go on. The culture of the college allows my team to play with food from around the world.

Who's the most interesting diner you've had to cater for and what was the dish?

At the age of 17 I was fortunate to have the honour to cook for the Queen. She was a guest at the college, and the dinner was for 300.

Starter: Smoked Salmon Bavaois

Main: Pan Seared Guinea Fowl Breast, Wild Mushrooms, Gratin Dauphinois

Dessert: Choux Swan, Chantilly Cream, Wild Berries

Imagine you had to propose a dish to become known as THE Reuben college dish. What dish would you invent/suggest?

We have already started on this journey and have several in the pipeline for future proofing.

The Reuben Mess, a play on the Eton mess, but ours is a seasonal dish which incorporates Rhubarb as the main fruit and is very much a more formal looking dessert than the Eton one which happened by accident. We are also becoming well known for our ethos in using vegetables in desserts as we can get a lot of sweetness and flavour profiles that not only change people's mindset but also add additional nutrition to our food.

What is the best way for Reuben students to express their appreciation for the kitchen staff?

We think that this is already done. When we see the hall at breakfast, lunch and dinner the vibes we get and the happy faces make us think we do a good job. A very well-known saying in the kitchen is 'we are only as good as our last meal' - this keeps us well and truly on our toes!!

Nick SLEE

Pastry Chef & Baker



How did you start in the food industry, and what led you to Reuben's kitchen?

4-year apprenticeship at Jesus college, 7-8 years at Pembroke College, left catering for four years and became a fulltime martial arts instructor in the West Country. I returned to cooking at New College as third chef and quickly moved up to sous chef, where I spent 20+ years. It was time for a change building up my martial arts schools, as well as taking on smaller roles in the kitchen.

What's it like working in the Reuben kitchen?

It's been great for me!

Who's the most interesting diner you've had to cater for and what was the dish?

Rick Stein: sea bass with tomato and basil pesto - simple but cooked well.

Imagine you had to propose a dish to become known as THE Reuben college dish. What dish would you invent/suggest?

Ice cream bomb.

What is the best way for Reuben students to express their appreciation for the kitchen staff?

Simple - just say hi.

Dominic SLEE

Head Chef



How did you start in the food industry, and what led you to Reuben's kitchen?

I started as a Kitchen Porter at New College and gained a massive interest in food. I then did my apprenticeship at Christ Church College. I have worked in various restaurants, hotels and colleges and then found my way into Reuben College about 16 months ago in my first Head Chef role.

What's it like working in the Reuben kitchen?

Amazing. I love the team we've built and the vibe we have created around the kitchen and in the dining

hall. The students and staff are amazing and it's a pleasure to make them meals everyday.

What dish do you most remember growing up with?

My all-time favorite dish to eat is mac & cheese!! My mum always made it every Tuesday so because of that, I'm addicted to it!

Imagine you had to propose a dish to become known as THE Reuben college dish. What dish would you invent/suggest?

We've already made it! Our confit carrot starter on our conference menu is one of my all-time faves. The reason for this is because it's the first dish we've created that produces zero waste from making it. The peel, carrot tops and even the juice are all used for the dish, so this is the one I would associate with Reuben as a whole.

What is the best way for Reuben students to express their appreciation for the kitchen staff?

All we ask for is a please and thank you!

**Robert
RUDMAN**
Senior Sous Chef



How did you start in the food industry, and what led you to Reuben's kitchen?

So, I trained at Keble College for 3 years then went onto University College for 6 years. I worked in St Cross College for 25 years (22 years as Head Chef) under BaxterStorey. Unfortunately, BaxterStorey lost the contract which led me to Reuben College.

What's it like working in the Reuben kitchen?

It's a fun, friendly and fast paced kitchen and it's good to see another postgrad college doing things differently.

Who's the most interesting diner you've had to cater for and what was the dish?

I was fortunate to cook for and meet one-on-one with Sir David Attenborough at St Cross College.

Imagine you had to propose a dish to become known as THE Reuben college dish. What dish would you invent/suggest?

Fish and Chips but Deluxe! Beer Battered Cod, Triple Cooked Chips, Minted Mushy Peas and Homemade Tartare Sauce with a Malt Vinegar Gel.

What is the best way for Reuben students to express their appreciation for the kitchen staff?

Polite interaction with all the staff, please and thank you.

Amanda CLARE

Hospitality Supervisor



How did you start in the food industry, and what led you to Reuben's kitchen?

I started working for BaxterStorey in 2011 at St Cross College where I was a general assistant. Then I became a barista and was running the coffee shop in 2017. I joined Reuben's kitchen in January this year. I wanted to work here because I enjoy the college atmosphere and, of course, the team here are fantastic. I already knew everyone before I joined. I work alongside Shariq who is a great team player and taught me how things work at Reuben.

What's it like working in the Reuben kitchen?

I really enjoy working here. It's a fun place to be. Every day is different. Some days are busier than others. We have some very talented chefs in the kitchen and we all work really well together. We support each other fully. It's like a family. The building is beautiful and my favourite place is Abbot's Kitchen. I really enjoy setting up for special events.

What's your favourite dish that somebody else taught you how to make?

I love cooking at home. I have many dishes I like cooking but my favourite thing to cook is roast dinner. My dad taught me how to cook it.

Imagine you had to propose a dish to become known as THE Reuben college dish. What dish would you invent/suggest?

Oh I have no idea, I'm not a chef. But I do know all the food that is cooked in the kitchen by Dom, Joseph, Rob, Nick and Paul is made with love and passion!

What is the best way for Reuben students to express their appreciation for the kitchen staff?

I have many students at the till compliment the food, and it shows because they come back day after day. So that says it all really.



Photo credit: Katherine Faulkner and Puyu Wang

Reuben Sports: Spring & Summer Updates

Enno Schäfer, Sports Officer; MSc in Neuroscience

Eliza Rayner, RBC Co-Captain; DPhil in Interdisciplinary Biosciences

Jowan Fromentin, RFC President; DPhil in Intelligent Earth



Credit: Eliza Rayner

It has been a brilliant few months for sports at Reuben. As Trinity Term comes to a close, there is plenty to celebrate and even more to look forward to.

Rowing

The Reuben Boat Club has now existed for three years and continues to go from strength to strength. Our novice intake in Michaelmas made great progress, but sadly we couldn't row all Hilary Term due to persistent rain and very high streams. Our rowers were finally

allowed back on the water in spring and were greeted by soaring temperatures!

Summer Eights is the most important race in the college rowing calendar, and both our open and women's squads have risen dramatically up the rankings since the club's inception. This year, the women went +2, bumping on three of the four racing days. The men finished -1 after facing some tough opposition and showed some great rowing, including a strong row-over and a bump on

Hertford M2. RBC has also spread its wings to regattas outside of Oxford this year – a women's crew had a fantastic time racing Bedford Regatta and we have plans to enter Henley T&V too.

Reuben members also competed with distinction at the university level during Boat Race weekend. Lilli Freischem secured a winner's medal as part of the Oxford Women's crew, while Evan Albers raced in the Men's Reserve Crew and Lara Robinson was selected for the

Women's Spare 4+, a testament to the depth of rowing talent we have at Reuben.



Whether you could be our next Boat Race athlete or just want to give it a go, you are always welcome – contact a captain any time of year!

Football

As another season of Reuben football has come to an end, the rumours of Reuben's first preembryonic attempt at a football club seem to have ebbed. Whilst the season was littered with cherished moments of jubilation, we finished with two wins in nine in the lowest graduate league. Our rough patch has started to overshadow the institutional memory of three seasons ago -

where Reuben played a game without boots and lost 15-0. But the people who have turned up every week deserve the credit for making the club a joy to play in.

The club has just limped out of its Trinity futsal tournament (a type of indoor football originating in Uruguay). The timetable, designed for an undergrad audience, with matches at all times of the day, made it rather challenging for our large cohort of teachers. Bring on half term!

Bring on next season, and let's keep these modest gains going!

Looking Ahead: Racquets and Beyond

With the summer term in full swing, outdoor courts are starting to open up, electrifying every racquets player. As the college has secured Reuben members access to Wadham sports grounds, we are excited to announce the Reuben Racquets Club, which brings together both tennis and badminton under one roof, or rather, one court.

In the meantime, our badminton players have been competing in Cuppers, with the women's team making it to the finals and the men's to the semifinals. We wish them well for the final, decisive matches!

Meanwhile, for those looking for something a little more leisurely, the tennis programme is officially getting underway. Whether you're a seasoned player or just want to enjoy a knockabout in the sun, all are

welcome to rent out tennis racquets and show their skills on the Wadham courts. For more information, just join the WhatsApp community!

Sports at Reuben continues to excite both competitive and leisurely sporting students. None of it would be possible without the students who show up, compete, and make these teams what they are. If you're not yet involved and would like to be, whether it's rowing, football, tennis, badminton, or anything else, please do get in touch. Also, don't forget to use your sports funds: Roundnet sets, volleyball nets and all the other sports gear are waiting to be taken to Uni Parks and all other sports grounds. There is always room for more!

We hope you can enjoy the summer!



Photos from Ukraine

Kateryna Kuzminova, MSc in Modelling for Global Health

Snapshots from Nyžnia Syrowatka. 30 km from the frontline, we work the land, love our dogs, support the military, and see beauty in the world.



Sumy Train Station

Soldier's underwear drying on Tchaikovsky's 19th century summer house



Princess curtains on soldier's room



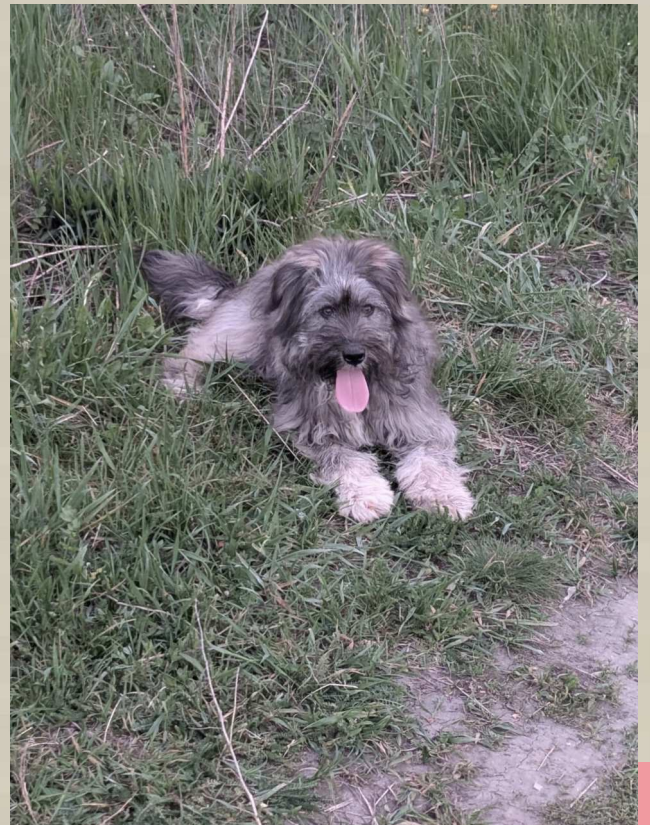
Burning Buildings, painted by Kate during Art Society

Field

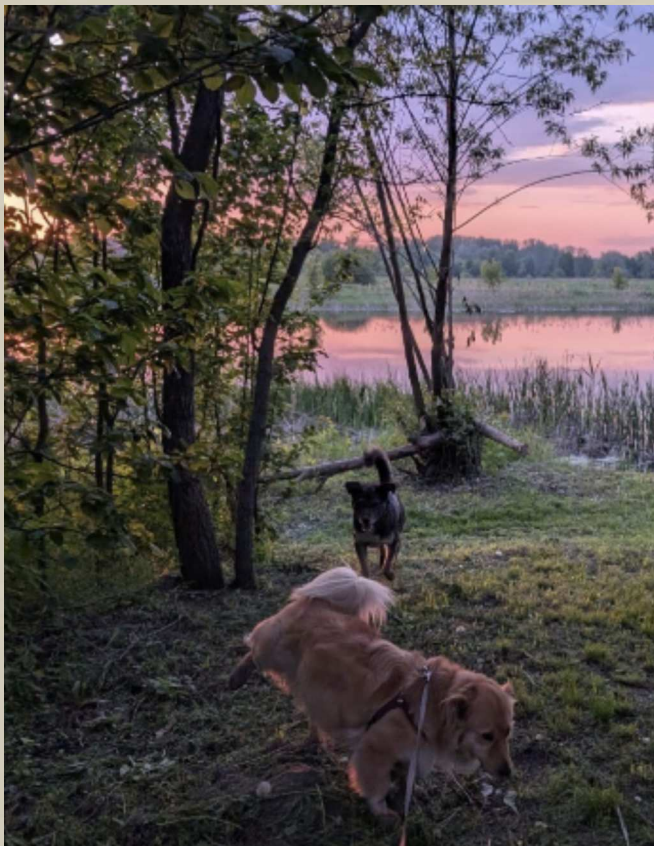




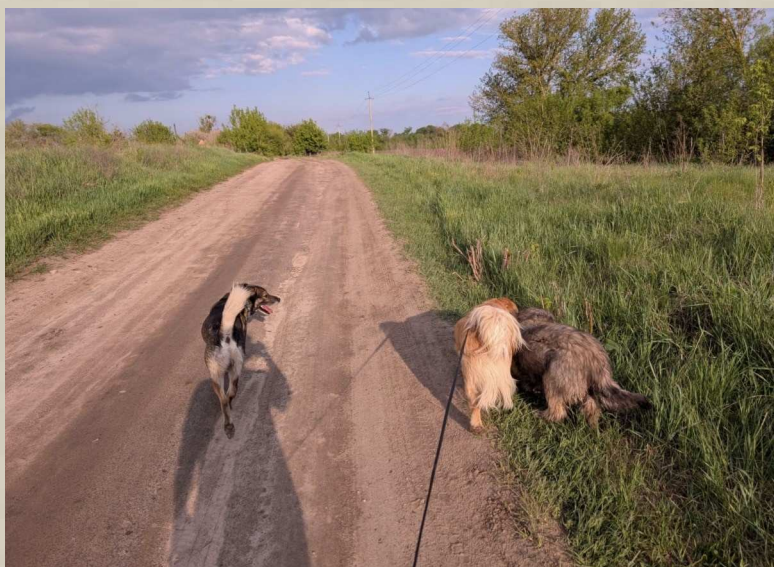
Stork perched on top of nest



Real name unknown, but
Kate calls him Chugaistryk

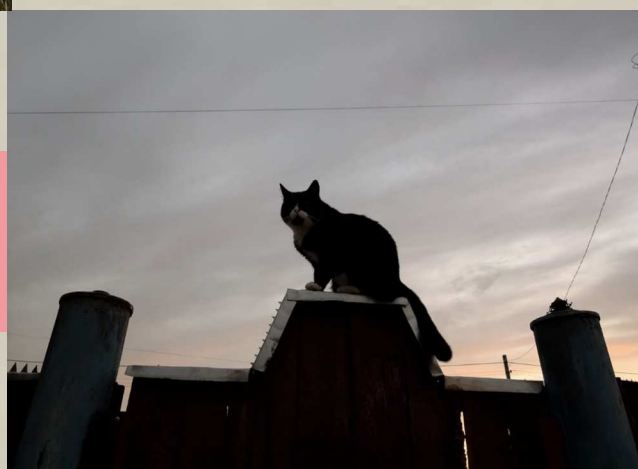


Persyk on a walk



Dogs on a walk. From left to right: Jack, Persyk, and Chugaistryk. Jack is the recent father of two litters. Congratulations, Jack!

Tom the cat surveying the land



Kate and Persyk



Kate recommends supporting UAnimals—the largest Ukrainian charity organisation for rescuing animals from the frontline areas.



Flying Blind: Preparing for a Career in the Era of AI

Joseph Miller, DPhil in Engineering Science

I started coding when I was thirteen. I published my first app when I was seventeen. I studied computer science at undergrad and did programming internships during my summers. My first job was as a software engineer and coding has been a part of every job I've had since. It was my main hobby and favourite pastime for most of my adult life so in total, I've put in many thousands of hours of practice. It's the thing in life that I am best at.

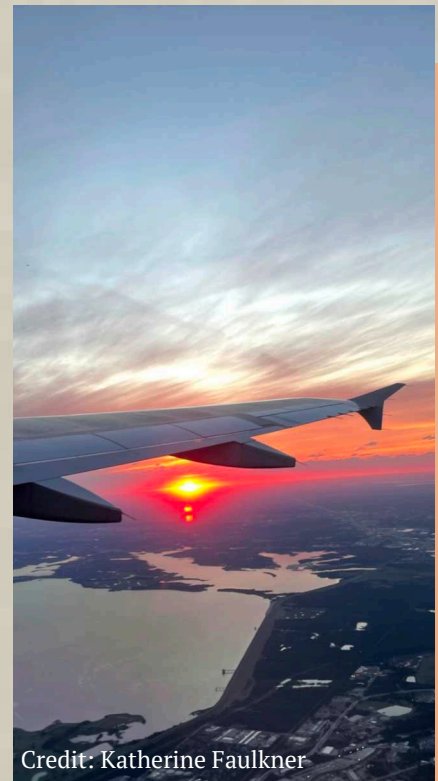
I haven't written a line of code for almost six months. It was six months ago that we crossed a threshold where it no longer made sense for me to type my own code. Instead, it was more efficient to tell the AI what to write for me. Then, three months ago, I mostly stopped reading the code. The AI writes it and only the AI reads it.

My career as a software engineer, if I wanted to continue it, is at this point clearly a dead end. It's inconceivable to me that software development in anything resembling its traditional form will exist in ten years. For a while, the programmers will still stick around, they'll just be managing at a higher level, directing teams of AIs. But that won't last. The AI will get better at that too.

I remember the period of time

when I had to emotionally adjust from thinking about advanced AI as a distant hypothetical possibility to a real, tangible probability that was in my future. The moment that stuck in my mind was the first time, in early 2022, that I saw a language model explaining a joke. I remember the dread I felt when it hit me on a gut level that we had overcome one of the hard problems of artificial intelligence. Finally we had an AI that could talk. A problem that had seemed impenetrable, a problem for which it is hard to know how to begin, a problem researchers had tried and failed for decades to make progress on, had suddenly been solved in a few short years by relatively simple techniques.

Some philosophers and psychologists talk about the difference between near mode and far mode thinking. Far mode is where you think abstractly about speculations and hypothetical possibilities. Near mode is where you think about ideas that are real and tangible to your everyday life. When you think about the question 'how should an ideal society organise transportation?', you probably think in far mode. When you think about the question 'how should I get to work today?', you probably think in near mode.



Credit: Katherine Faulkner

The biggest mistake most people are making with AI today is thinking about human-level and superhuman AI in far mode instead of near mode. Advanced AI is no longer a danger to be speculated about in a philosophy classroom, it's a problem that we need to make a plan for right now. I hear people saying things like, "Oh, it wouldn't be so bad if humans went extinct." Or, "The real problem isn't AI, it's humans / capitalism / the internet." Ideas that sound profound, or perhaps reflect some ideals that the speaker has, but which do not present useful solutions to the actual problem facing us.

In near mode, AI automation means your career plan to become a stock trader, software engineer or journalist is probably not going to work out, and you should think of something else. In near mode, you don't accept vague, rhetorical ideas of equitable AI. In near mode, you demand real tax reforms that will keep the state functioning when most people are unemployable through no fault of their own.

More and more people are becoming aware of the situation we're in. In my work at PauseAI, I meet them every day. I welcome new people into the movement. I comfort them and tell them that they are not alone. There are other people out there who are thinking in near mode about advanced AI. We are still relatively few and far between. Many people won't necessarily know anyone in their own circles, and it can be a relief to meet others that see what you see.

AI is on a trajectory that is unprecedented for any technology. Hundreds of billions were invested last year in new data centers and this year may be trillions. AI companies are growing in revenue faster than any other companies in the history of capitalism. The pace of improvement is overwhelming. Most benchmarks created more than a year ago are saturated, and the improvement of frontier models is almost beyond our ability to measure. The best metric now is the amount of professional labour that a model can replace. The list of tasks that AI can

complete gets longer every month. Crucially, and most dangerously, AI is beginning to gain skills that substantially accelerate the process of AI development itself.

Talk of an 'AI bubble' is a major distraction that is mostly irrelevant. OpenAI may collapse, seed funding for startups may collapse, but that will not stop the progress. As long as more compute equals more capabilities, Google, Microsoft, Amazon, xAI and Meta will continue to keep building bigger data centers. There is too much profit on the line for them to let the opportunity pass.



The most disruptive technology ever is being developed in a race with no regulation and no time for caution.

The CEOs leading the charge tell students to learn 'AI skills' and critical thinking to prepare for employment in a post-AI world. Many will see through the ruse. There is no employment in a post-AI world. Just as AI can already do their exams better than they can, students are starting to realise that AI will be able to do their jobs better as well. Already we see fewer entry-

level positions, as AIs can automate many of the tasks that would previously be given to new grads.

The risk of human extinction is mostly ignored and rarely even part of the AI conversation in many circles. I refrained from making it more prominent in this article for fear of losing readers. But nonetheless, the world's top experts have issued dire warnings about our ability to maintain control over superhuman AI, or even align it with our interests. Unemployment is a problem that we will get to deal with if and when we overcome the direct risk to our safety. Just as the world's failure to seriously engage with early climate scientists did not make climate change any less of a threat, ignoring the civilisational risk of rogue AI does not change the seriousness of this danger either.

The effects of introducing a competitor to the human species will ripple across the planet, and the ultimate consequences are almost impossible to imagine. What is clear is that we are flying blind. The most disruptive technology ever is being developed in a race with no regulation and no time for caution. That is why I want to slow down. That is why I and others in PauseAI are advocating for international cooperation. The world's AI companies are making a reckless gamble with our future and we desperately need to find a different approach.

From Gilgamesh to Gollum

How a 4,000-year-old Sumerian poem inspired *The Lord of the Rings*

Daniel Revach, DPhil in Experimental Psychology



Credit: Daniel Revach

Stories help us understand what it means to be human. Their eerily ancient and common origins prove that our creative, self-conflicted, meaning-seeking nature persists across time and space. *The Lord of the Rings* is one of the best-selling and most influential stories ever written. What if it wasn't conceived in a study at Oxford, but at the dawn of civilisation?

It should hardly come as a surprise that J.R.R. Tolkien drew inspiration from famous stories. Norse mythology echoes through Arda's creatures, deities, and themes. Túrin Turambar owes his grim existence to the Finnish *Kalevala*, and Middle Earth's Elves to the Irish magical *Aos Sí*. What of the Greek myth about the Ring of Gyges, which turns its bearer invisible? The list goes on: *The Ring of the Nibelung*, *Beowulf*, *King Arthur*, and let's not forget the Bible, from whose threads the *Silmarillion* was woven. But few know of a text far older than all others, nearly as old as writing itself that traversed cultures, languages, fires, floods

and oblivion, to reach the hungering mind of an Oxford professor.

At the ripe age of four thousand, *The Epic of Gilgamesh* is the oldest known work of literature. Born in Mesopotamia, modern day Iraq, the Sumerian poems provided the core material for *The Epic*, which was written in Babylonian around 1,700 BC. The most complete version we have dates back to the 7th century BC.

The Epic centres around the legendary Gilgamesh, king of the city of Uruk, and his adventures with his rival-become-friend Enkidu. The two venture to the cedar mountain to fight Humbaba, Guardian of the Forest. They return home only to face the Bull of Heaven. Finally, the victorious Gilgamesh embarks on a lonely journey in pursuit of immortality.

It is a tale full of introspection, internal conflict, philosophy, wit, profanities, and narrative depth that would earn acclaim

to any modern novel or film. A hero's journey and morally grey characters take us through a mythological landscape foundational to the core texts of modern culture, Western and Eastern.

More controversial is the claim that *The Epic* was seminal to our world-renowned philologist, but the similarities are all too striking to Tolkien's magnum opus, *The Lord of the Rings*. The plot structure of *The Epic* fits the trilogy like a glove. To demonstrate this, I'll use Benjamin Foster's 2019 translation of *The Epic of Gilgamesh*.

**'Nine companions. So be it.
You shall be the fellowship of
the ring.'**

Assembled before the council in his city of Uruk, Gilgamesh announces his and Enkidu's plan to slay the evil Humbaba on his dark mountain. Much like Sauron, Humbaba is not the kind of spirit you want to mess with. It is said "his maw is fire, his

breath is death... Adad [the storm god] is first^[1], and Humbaba is second."

Gilgamesh asks for the council's blessing. The baneful enemy must be eradicated, after which the land will rejoice. Though the young men support his cause, the terrified elders try to dissuade him; only after some back and forth do they concede. Then Gilgamesh and Enkidu take up "the great daggers, the bow and the quiver in their hands [and] the axes." A sword, a bow and an axe, anyone?

A different version strengthens the similarity with the council of Elrond. Reaching the god Utu's sanctuary, the companions ask for his help. Despite fearing Gilgamesh's fate, Utu recognises his noble spirit and gives him and Enkidu seven wondrous warriors to protect and guide them on their journey. One has lion paws and eagle talons, another resembles a dragon snake. The nine leave the sanctuary to travel to the far-away mountain and defeat the evil Humbaba.

There you have it: both stories

depict a hero and his friend reaching a wise supernatural being, who after a heated council sends them off to the enemy's dark territory with seven brave sword, bow and axe-wielding companions. Coincidence? Let's keep going.

'We loves master'

Humbaba might seem like your average evil Maia, but the haunting complexity the Mesopotamians gave this character may have inspired one of Tolkien's more unique creatures.

Shadow covers the cedar mountain. As the fellowship traverses, Humbaba follows, lurking in the shadows, his eyes making their skin crawl. Finally, he confronts Gilgamesh and Enkidu. A ferocious battle ensues, and ultimately the Guardian of the Forest is defeated.

He is dragged and held down by Gilgamesh. His arms are tied together. Suddenly, the monster bursts into tears, weeping and wailing, clutching the king by the hand and pleading with

glossy puss-in-boots eyes: "I was born in the mountain land. My mother... was a cavern in the mountain, my father... was a peak in the mountain, O Utu, let me live by myself, alone in the mountain!" In another version, Humbaba makes Gilgamesh quite the offer: "A living slave is profitable for his master... You will be master, wherever I am."

Like Gollum, this pathetic sob works on our protagonist, who takes pity on his foe and finds him a job: "let him be our guide, let him carry my pack." Like Sam, Enkidu the side-kick is not convinced, insisting that Humbaba will lead them to their demise. He implores the king not to listen to the creature's lies, and urges him to finish the job, at which point Humbaba snaps at Enkidu. Unlike Frodo, Gilgamesh did not have a wise wizard to teach him the meaning of pity. The king and his companion give the wretched creature a brutal death.

Only then does the horrifying sight of their actions dawn on them, provoking a passage whose echo haunts the 21st century: "We have made wasteland of the forest. How shall we answer for it?"

Here too the similarities are remarkable: a creepy, morally ambiguous Jekyll-and-Hyde creature 'born' in the mountain caves stalks the company and is subdued; the companion advises killing the creature, who offers himself as servant to his



Left: Ancient clay carving depicting Gilgamesh and Enkidu fighting Humbaba.
Right: Gollum in the mountain caves, artwork by Frédéric Bennett.

[1] Our more erudite readers might notice the similarity with Melkor, the chief evil god who had Sauron as his second-in-command.

'master', and is considered for the role of guide.

'Living or dark undead, I will smite you'

After this feat, both heroic and despicable, Gilgamesh and Enkidu return to Uruk. The glorious city, considered one of the first in human history, is described with an eye-catching characteristic: like Minas Tirith, it possesses seven gates, which may or may not imply seven concentric walls.

Here, an even greater battle takes place. Turned down by her beloved Gilgamesh, the goddess Ishtar stands on the ramparts and lets out a scream that "reached the heaven [and] the netherworld... She spread terror." The vengeful deity thus summons the Bull of Heaven to destroy king and city. This monstrous, winged beast wreaks havoc in Uruk, akin to the Nazgul-bearing Fellbeast in Minas Tirith.

Meanwhile, the king is eating and drinking in the comfort of his palace. A minstrel – let's call him Pippin – informs the king of the catastrophe brought upon

the city, urging him to take action. Like Denethor, Gilgamesh won't budge. He orders his minstrel to tune his strings and sing. Fortunately, he soon has a change of heart: the king prepares for battle.

Together with Enkidu, they challenge the Bull of Heaven, who "bellowed in the dust." Like Eowyn and Merry, our duo only barely outmatches the bull. Gilgamesh smites it on the head, and in a beautifully gory description, the bull "reared up and up till it fell over backwards and splattered everywhere like slime." The calamity has been averted. But unlike the Witch King, Ishtar will not be killed today by either man or woman.

Three is a pattern? A seven-gated city is assailed by a supernatural being riding a winged beast; the city's ruler is reluctant to fight despite his minstrel's plea; the two heroes face the villain, give the beast a fatal blow, and save the day.

Among the cornucopia of parallels, we might briefly mention Tolkien's Uruk-hai who, similar to the pair of Uruk-folk Gilgamesh and Enkidu, assault Fangorn Forest and its

guardian Treebeard. Or perhaps Aragorn, Legolas and Gimli, who, like *The Epic's* duo, travel a great distance at fantastic speed to reach the forest, where Gandalf, like Humbaba, paralyses the heroes with a blinding light. And what about our protagonists' ultimate journey deep into the land of shadow, be it Mordor or the Underworld? In fact, Gilgamesh's story concludes with a beautiful scene reminiscent of the trilogy's ending. But for that, you'll have to read *The Epic* for yourselves.

An Expected Journey?

Is this similarity a product of humankind's psychological and cultural propensities? Or would Tolkien have conceded that his masterpiece is so indebted to its most ancient ancestor? I believe he would have proudly proclaimed it. The philologist who dreamt of creating a mythology for England knew that every nation's tales organically sprout from humanity's shared genealogy of myths and folklore; that true relatives should resemble; that tongue and quill must tirelessly transfer the soul's DNA and its myriad mutations. With her colourful characters and imaginative depiction of Man's struggle against world and self, Mesopotamia's silver-haired muse may well reside by the roots of that family tree.

But what are your thoughts, dear reader? Is the Professor guilty as charged in this tale of two epics?



Left: Ancient clay carving depicting Gilgamesh and Enkidu fighting the Bull of Heaven. Right: *The Witch King atop his Fell Beast*, artwork by John Howe.

Reuben Research

An Ode to Magazines

Megan Phillips, MSt in US History

I never read magazines growing up. Okay, I may have bought the occasional edition for the free gift, but I did not care for fashion, or celebrity gossip, or relationship advice. You see them lying around on waiting room tables or at the hairdressers, a quick boredom fix that doesn't require your full attention. Honestly, I had always considered them the fast fashion of print media – less serious than newspapers, less complex than novels. So, it probably comes as a surprise that I'm now a historian researching American women's magazines at the turn of the twentieth century.

As it turns out, magazines are far more than easy reading. During the late nineteenth century, America faced the rise of industrialism, consumerism, and all kinds of social change, from the increasingly-popular suffrage movement to prohibition. Suddenly, women were the backbone of the nation's consumer economy. Advertisers quickly realised the potential new market, and magazines became the perfect real estate to entice these readers. Women shaped the market and the market shaped women. As the iconic Miranda Priestly says in *The Devil Wears Prada*, 'You think that you've made a choice that exempts you from the fashion industry when, in fact, you're wearing the sweater that was selected for you by the people in this room'. Before television and social media, magazines were the influencers of the day.

Now, I still have a love-hate relationship with the consumerist nature of magazines, but they did have their merits. Magazines also contained literature, art, and poetry (much like our *Reuby*), allowing many to publish their work for a national audience. This was an important avenue for women in a time when their talents were often disregarded. During the World Wars and the Great Depression, magazines were important in providing news, hope, and morale to the ladies at home, educating them about their duties on the Home Front, being thrifty on a budget, and balancing paid work and housework. When I stumbled upon a century-old article fretting about the 'cost of living', I was, as historians often are, struck with the innate feeling that our shared human experiences will forever transcend not just space, but time as well – the worries of bygone women echoing in the social media posts of newer generations.

Nevertheless, magazines provided a much needed escape from the stresses of daily life, and a chance to envision a lifestyle only some could afford. They were, as Nigel aptly states in *The Devil Wears Prada*, 'a shining beacon of hope' for millions of readers. I'm not suggesting that *The Reuby* is going to be changing thousands of minds (one can only hope!), but our magazine preserves the very traditions established decades ago, showcasing the creative literature, art, and poetry of Reuben's students, and enshrining their work for future students to see.



This cover of the Ladies' Home Journal depicts the annual pumpkin parade at Randolph-Macon Woman's College, illuminating the changing attitudes towards women and education by the turn of the century. Cover by Harrison Fisher, Ladies' Home Journal, October 1905.

Measuring the Unmeasurable

What rankings can't tell us

Meruyert Bizhanova, DPhil in Education



University rankings have become a defining feature of higher education worldwide, shaping how universities are evaluated, compared, and positioned across countries. Rankings such as QS and Times Higher Education increasingly influence institutional priorities and definitions of success.

This raises a central question: what does 'reputation' actually mean in higher education, and how is it understood in different national and institutional contexts?

My research focuses on Kazakhstan, a post-Soviet country where the higher education

system has undergone major transformation since independence in 1991. The sector has expanded from a small number of centrally governed institutions into a more diverse system that includes public, private, and regional universities. Alongside this expansion, universities are increasingly encouraged to compete internationally and improve their positions in global rankings.

However, global ranking systems are largely based on Western models of higher education and may not fully reflect the institutional realities of countries like Kazakhstan. This creates a structural tension: universities are expected to compete in global terms while also responding to national and local priorities. Against this background, my research asks how different types of universities in Kazakhstan understand and pursue 'reputation.' It examines whether universities define success primarily through global rankings, or whether alternative forms of national and local recognition also matter. My work also explores how institutional resources, histories, and constraints shape the ways reputation is constructed and pursued in practice.

By comparing public, private, and regional universities, my work shows that reputation is not a fixed or universal concept. Rather, it is context-dependent and actively constructed within specific institutional environments. This matters because reputation increasingly shapes funding decisions, student recruitment, academic hiring, and international collaboration. Yet we still know relatively little about how universities in post-Soviet contexts experience and respond to these global pressures.

It is to be noted that universities operate under different structural conditions. Their understandings of success are shaped not only by global ranking systems, but also by historical legacies, institutional resources, and local realities. In today's knowledge economy, where rankings have become a dominant form of measurement, it is important to think critically about how knowledge is produced and valued, what is considered valid, how it is framed, and whether it is transferable across contexts. It also invites reflection on what may be missing from dominant measures of success in higher education, and what alternative understandings might be possible.

Would You Trust ChatGPT as a Health Information Source?

Sergej Kucenko, MSc in Applied Digital Health



Large language models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT are becoming increasingly popular as health information sources. Studies have shown that they are capable of providing accurate health information (Aydin et al., 2024); however, there have also been reports of unsafe outputs and incorrect information provided to users (Draelos et al., 2025; Moore et al., 2025). While extensive research has focused on the quality of these LLMs (e.g., accuracy), it is also important to investigate public and patient trust in these tools. For example, overreliance on LLM responses may lead individuals to act on information without consulting clinicians or cross-checking the information through other sources. On the other hand, low trust could discourage people from using LLMs despite their potential to provide accurate, timely, and accessible health information.

Previous reviews have examined the accuracy of LLM-generated health information (Waldock et al., 2024), patients' perceptions of AI use in healthcare (Moy et al., 2024), and health consumers' use and perceptions of health information provided by generative AI chatbots (Bautista et al., 2025). However, there is yet to be a review specifically focused on public and patient trust in LLMs as health information sources. My MSc dissertation aims to address this gap by identifying and mapping the evidence in this emerging area. A scoping review was considered the most suitable review type for (1) mapping the

evidence, (2) examining how trust is conceptualised, (3) identifying both recurring and conflicting findings, (4) describing the methods used, and (5) identifying gaps in the literature. PubMed, Scopus, arXiv, IEEE Xplore, and Google Scholar were searched for studies reporting quantitative or qualitative evidence on public or patient trust in LLMs as health information sources. The literature review will provide recommendations for future research and the further development of LLMs to improve their safety and effectiveness in providing health information. This work can also inform public information and guidance provision regarding LLM use for health information and discussions around the role of LLMs within health information and care-seeking pathways.



My masters work follows my previous research on digital health issues and trustworthy AI, which motivated me to pursue the MSc in Applied Digital Health. The review also informs my planned PhD research on public perceptions and use of LLMs as health information sources. Please feel free to reach out to me on LinkedIn (<http://www.linkedin.com/in/sergej-kucenko-9303a1205>) if you have any questions or would like to discuss digital health or trustworthy AI research!

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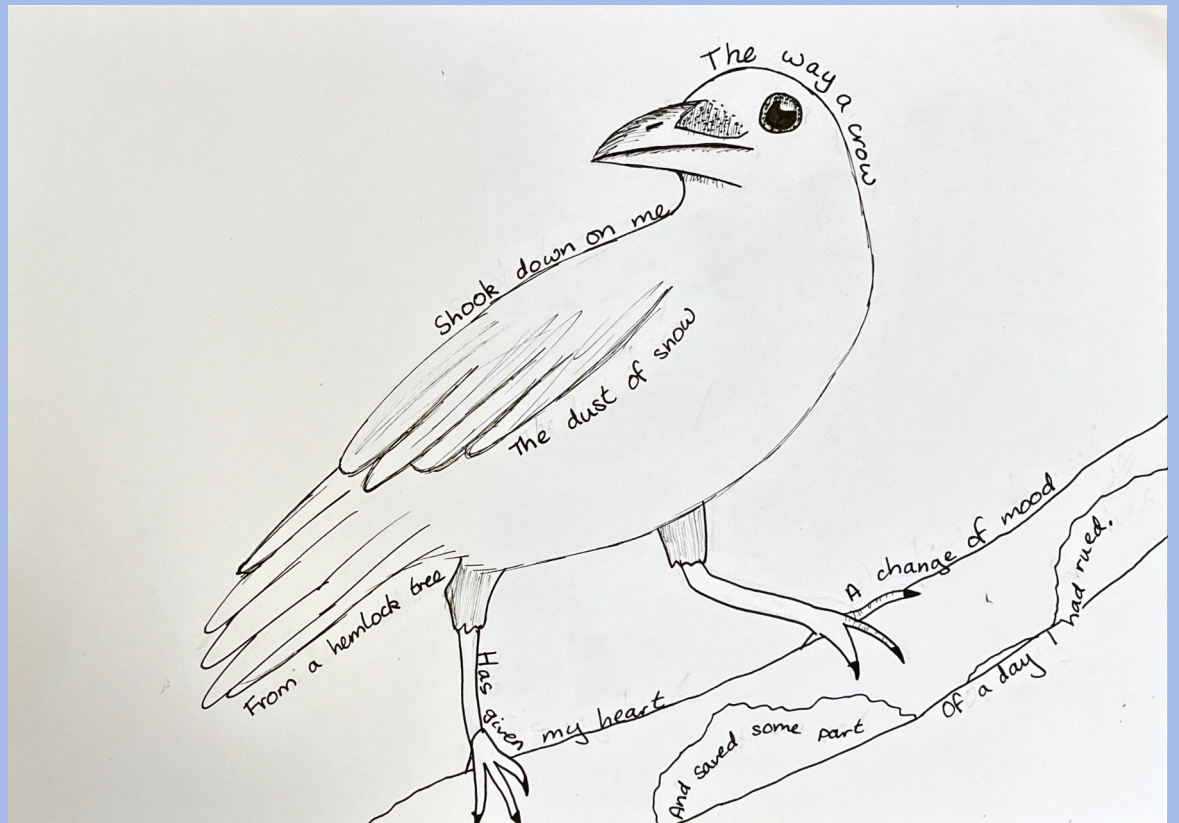
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Soup in Art

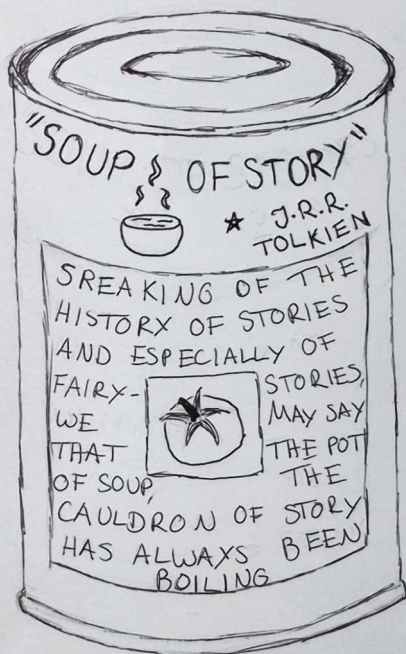
Reuben Art Society



Joy Lai



Sophie Brixton



Megan Phillips

Insights Festival Art Competition Winner



Robert Lu's art piece titled *A more complete picture of infectious disease* is the proud winner of the 2025 Reuben Insights Festival Art competition. The contest gave students the opportunity to submit artwork that represents their research or interests. The pieces were then featured at the Insights Festival, where members of the public voted for their favourite artwork. Robert's first-prize illustration depicts his virus-vaccine model of influenza. If you look closely, you may even notice how each microbiome component is displayed in the colour commonly used to stain and image them in the lab. This original and masterful marriage of science and art results in a hauntingly beautiful interrogation of reality.

A more complete picture of infectious disease

Robert Lu, DPhil in Biology

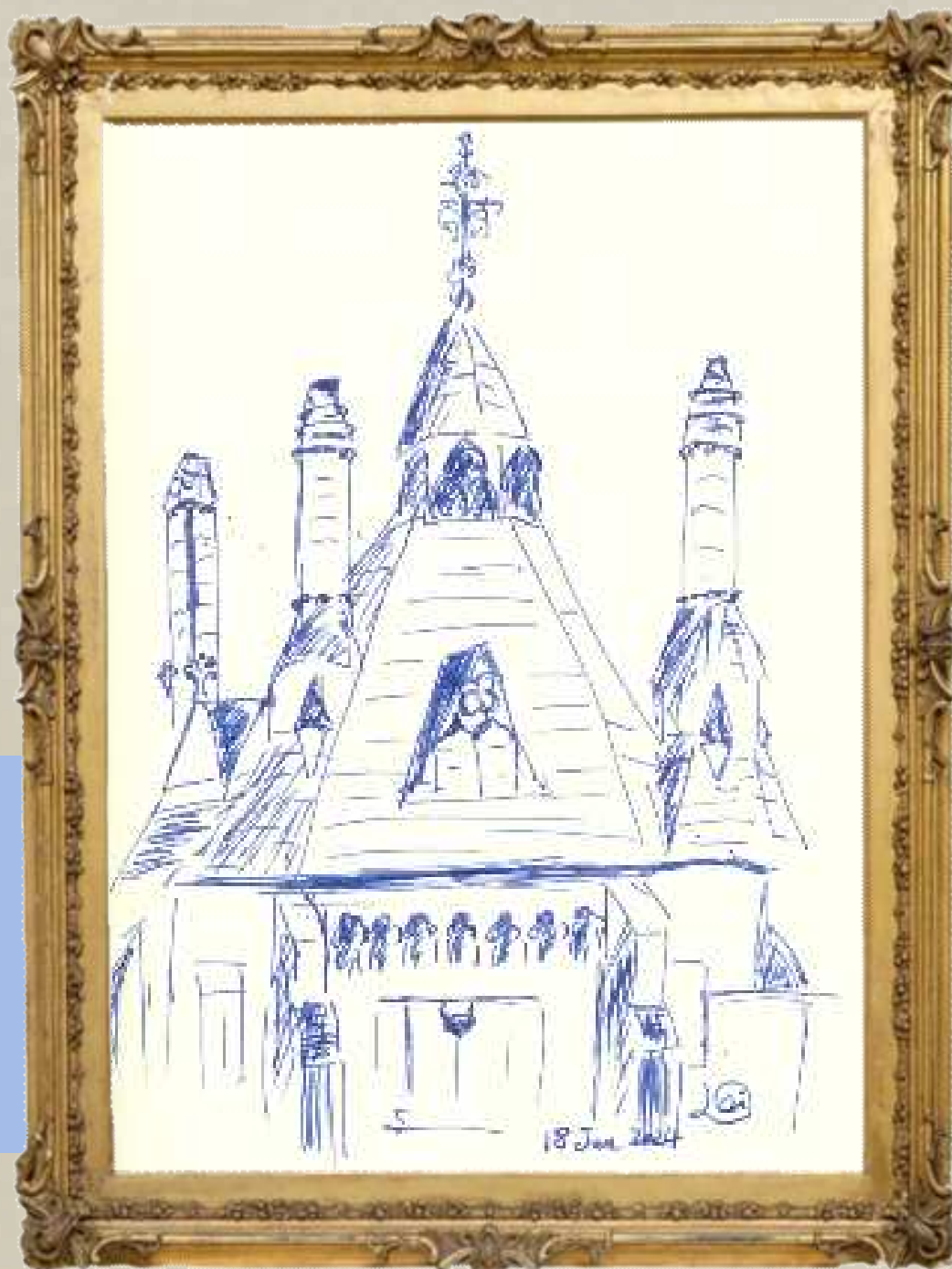
Scientific evidence increasingly points to the microbiome's importance in disease immunity, influencing both courses of infection, and the effectiveness of treatments and prophylaxes (e.g., vaccination). I research a virus-vaccine model involving rodent-adapted influenza, and rodents transplanted with diverse microbiomes from various environments. My work aims to disentangle the effects of gastrointestinal microbes on immune development, immunization, and infection outcomes, ultimately aiming to uncover mechanisms underlying microbiome-mediated immunity.

In this piece, four drypoint plates stack into an influenza virion, with each plate bearing a different viral component. Looking closer, each virion drypoint contains a different microbiome component, whose ink colour matches a stain commonly used to image them: yeast with iodine, archaea with fluorescent green SYTO-9, gram-negative bacteria with fuchsin, and gram-positive bacteria with crystal violet—all spilling out from the linocut lab rat wrapped partway around. Together, these elements create, well, a more complete picture of an infectious disease.

Reuben Postcard Competition Winners

1st Place: Abbot's Kitchen, ink on paper using a fountain pen

Lei Clifton, Governing Body Fellow, AI & Machine Learning



Abbot's Kitchen is my favourite room of Reuben College, always catching my eye whenever I walk past. This sketch was my first attempt to capture its beauty on paper, drawn quickly while I was waiting to meet a friend for lunch at the College. I hope to create a watercolour piece featuring Abbot's Kitchen again in the near future.

2nd Place: Looking Down the Reuben Staircase

Agnibeena Ghosh, MSc in Digital Scholarship

The materials used for this piece: coloured tissue paper, marker, and pencil on A4 canvas paper. I generally like working with coloured markers for most artworks.

I was inspired to create this piece after attending an event arranged in collaboration with Reuben's Environment Society and the Museum of Climate Hope. After visiting the Oxford Museum of Natural History, we were asked to create an artwork based on a specimen of our choice, imagining a new display that incorporated both the specimen and something personally meaningful. I've always loved the view when looking down Reuben's staircase, so I chose to make that the setting of my piece. That became the spark for this artwork, and I also wanted to commemorate Reuben's Christmas tradition, especially since I'm part of the Reuben Student Choir myself.



Highly Commended: Abbot's Kitchen

Sarah Davidson, Communications & Events Manager

The Abbot's Kitchen is my favourite place in College – beautiful, traditionally Oxford, and such a distinctive part of Reuben. I always love seeing how it changes with the seasons and at different times of day. I created this image while drawing and making art with my daughter, so it became a blend of two different sides of my life: work and family.

Poetry Corner

Ode to an Old Machine

Isabella Savin, MSc(Res) in Biochemistry

The Geiger counter in the back lab
was forged with purpose down in Sandhurst
by a company that no longer exists.
Metal on heat on glass – all that fuss
just to lie in wait for decades, dormant as a rock,
shunned to the second shelf.
Students upon students use this tiny room,
concoct solutions in hardened beakers
and weigh enigmatic crystals down to the milligram
beneath the counter's ever-searching eyes.
After years of waiting with nothing to go on,
it simmers with silent rage
and yet still stands, militant,
a beacon in the chemical air,
a lighthouse that never shakes its dust,
but with no window, no rolling waves or rotting shipwrecks to keep
itself distracted,
what's it to do? Every so often, I grimace at its dials and buttons
to keep it on its toes, you know? No, of course not.
Right, sounds like I need coffee. I let the door shut behind me,
and in the back of my mind,
I imagine that forty miles away in Sandhurst
a man in a suit stands by an abandoned factory.
He shakes his fist at the air
beneath a canopy of tessellated leaves.
I like to think
I'll get it back to him
tied with a ribbon.

The Meadow

Katherine Faulkner, DPhil in Environmental Research

Warm hands gently yank me in
To a place I've long forgotten.
Your voice, giddy, tells me of
The meadow where I have rotten.
Bumble bees scream when buzzing by me.
Is it magma or sun on my skin?
The sweet scent of roses
It chokes me.
And yet
You don't see the storm on my face.
*How lucky are we
to be here in the spring?*
Excitement is plain in your tone.
I try not to wince when you roll in the grass
At the blades piercing your back.
I blink and you're fine
Sundress still intact.
I smile to mimic the mood.
The ice in my veins
Blurs my vision
And plays
What's now
And what's in the grave.
You couldn't know that
You shouldn't know that
The meadow can also bring harm.
The ravens have clawed out my skin and
The cottontails gnawed at my bones.
Spring showers have drowned me in
minutes
And fire ants swallowed me whole.
You couldn't know that
You'd never know that
Your companion is a ghost.
But I'll sit with you here for the moment
And your life will carry on.

Short Stories

Schatzi

Geneviève Helleringer, Governing Body Fellow, Values & Society; Faculty of Law

Content Warning: The following piece contains discussions of types of harm that some readers may find disturbing. Reader discretion is advised.

I.

I will have another glass. I need the uplift. Bottles empty quicker than they used to: another bit of my world collapsing. At least in my study, with my books, bottle, and cigarettes, I feel safe. When I push my chair back, the screeching on the floorboards sounds as familiar as a lullaby. The soft Iranian carpet lets me feel its matrix on the threadbare trail my bare feet have carved over four decades. I turn the cool porcelain doorknob, pull the study's door and become agitated—a vulnerable young pensioner assaulted by her daughter's screams. Camilla went back to her own children, for god's sake, but her fury is still shouting from the photo-frames angrily spilt on the floor. I wobble to the kitchen, banging on the sharp edges of the coffee table. I ignore the moldy dishes, the fetid bin-liner with its hernia of leftover pizza, and the humming companionship of feasting rodents. Back to my study with a fresh bottle of Gordon's, carefully avoiding the aggressive furniture. No glass needed. How can my cherished daughter, my partner in feminism, have become so savage? Ruthless jealousy is not reserved to the mighty Hera: it has displayed its horrid face in my living room. If it were good material for a novel, I would not resent the hassle so much, but, my dear Camilla, such a common plot takes us nowhere in the literary world. A divorced mother of two young children meets at a conference dinner a smart, handsome fellow university professor. The conversation is as natural as sex. She names the charming Prince "Schatzi" because he is her Schatz, her secret treasure. He cherishes her, opens superior claret for their ever-late dinners and smiles her anxieties away in their smoke-filled kitchen. He cares like a father for the little boy and girl. He organizes their vacations, snatching slots at the municipal tennis camp and hiring baby-sitters able to teach the crawl for their stay on Schatzi's family estate in the South of France. He accompanies the pair in their coming of age, liberally providing joints and time for passionate debates on the merits of collective property. However, envy has nested in the heart of the daughter. A wicked Snow White, green-eyed towards her mother the Queen. She could not seduce the charming Prince she loved, she will now try snatch him by force, ordering her bruised mother to abandon him.

II.

"If you knew something you ought to tell, you should have spoken up. Keeping silence for twenty odd years and then pretending to expose a secret? The bomb goes 'pschitt', it's off, it's fake, it's empty

slander". She sobs, "I couldn't speak to you, Mum. You were grieving Grandma's death, and later Grandpa's. I couldn't reach out to you." "I've been in my study day after day. You could've found me, had you wished to". I am not giving in to her sniffing. If anything, it makes me impatient. She did not speak, and she has the nerve to criticize the fact that I have decided to take my time, talk to Schatzi, decide what is appropriate. She would have me throw two books and a pullover in a bag and slam the door. "Go!" as she stamps, "go!". Had we had the conversation twenty years ago, things would have been different. But stamping one's foot does not erase time. Camilla cries because she is guilty. She and her brother left me in the dark. Victor left to the other end of the world long ago. But Camilla was around all this time. Her silence deprived me from understanding why Victor had grown distant, why he would never send his children to me and Schatzi for the vacation.

"I trusted you. Your silence betrayed my motherly confidence".

III.

I will have to protect Schatzi from Camilla's folly. Her frustration is palpable. I will not tolerate her staining the reputation of my beloved. I certainly do not want any nosy journalists turning up and seeing my face on days no one should be allowed to see it.

I will protect Schatzi as he protected me when Mother killed herself, and then when Father did the same.

IV.

Schatzi has become unquiet. He seems to keep his eyes open all night. He punches stronger. He talks about suicide. I need to ask Camilla: "Does Victor know you are punishing someone to death in his name? Does he approve? He used to prefer speaking for himself."

IV.

Gin is a woman's best friend. It clarifies the mind. I might not be fit, but I can find the strength and willpower to push away the distorted glasses Camilla is forcing onto my nose. Nothing she tells me incriminates Schatzi.

True, I did not hear anything about what was going on at that time. I don't remember Schatzi mentioning it; apparently, he had asked the twins to shut up about it because I was too tired. It is true it was a rough time. But I have fragmented memory. I used to collapse quickly after dinner and my nightcap. I still do.

In any case, a stepfather as involved in the education of his stepson, as Schatzi has been in Victor's, considers sensuality a perspective to open on a par with political debates and artistic or sporting activities. The honnête homme embraces it all.

Schatzi could practise with Victor what being a man allows. Masturbation used to be a social practice. No evil there.

And Camilla said it: there was no penetration. So, this is really much ado about nothing.

More concerning: Schatzi will be furious when he hears that Camilla has been here yet again and that I did not throw her out before she opened her mouth. I had better make sure I have supplies of ice, arnica, and camouflage cream.

Serenity

Jayroop Ramesh, DPhil in Computer Science



Rembrogan CCLVI picked up an ornate, rusted beast, its finer features lost to time. He ran his finger along its peculiar back bulges, oddly shaped toes and even odder but familiar etched markings. There was a key stuck in its back. He fiddled around until a winding motion seemed to "activate" this contraption. Its curved neck and long legs began whirring and perambulating with renewed purpose. He supposed that this mechanical wonder might have been revered in olden times, but reality demanded that his brief musing be cut short. He stood in the aftermath of yet another *afrit-factory* explosion, which meant it was up to him, and those like him, to clean up this mess. Centuries ago, his people stumbled onto a world-altering energy source through a fracture in space and time. Interdimensional beings wrought of smoke and fire. Non-sentient by all modern accounts of course, but harnessing their existence made nuclear power seem like electricity in comparison. Dominating them was child's play; they had no form of organizational resistance. And so, the world shifted. *Afrits* powered everything: vehicles, factories and homes. But most importantly, *afrits* powered *Serenity*, the virtual system where people got a second chance. *Serenity* was but a distant dream to someone of his station, but this job was a stepping stone to that far-fetched goal. He reminded himself why he was doing this as his eyes sparked with resolve. He tossed the toy away, pulled down his mask, and started to wade through the wreckage of machinery and people.

His mother used to tell him that his lack of a surname was a good thing, and it served to remind everyone how many centuries of peace had lasted since the great Illutari and Kangovan war. This was not very comforting to Rembrogan since everyone he knew also had this numerical identifier. Last names were held only by the nobles, the descendants of the heroes who were instrumental in ending the conflict all those years ago. He used to ask his mother, *why did the two kingdoms fight?* She parroted the response they all gave: *we hated the Illutari because they hated us.*

But why? Rem would push, but to his mother, it was enough to know it had *always* been that way. That being born in a certain region was enough to disqualify someone from humanity.

The polyolithic reminders of those days persisted. Large stone structures were scattered around the desolate landscape, extolling the virtues and legends of Illutari and Kangovan in ancient scripts that were ineffably alike. But nobody yet knew how. *Knowledge of ages? Or lies fabricated by the warmongering enemy?* He once fancied himself a seeker of secrets like the erudite elite. But therein lay the problem: it was limited to the privileged. Rem secretly taught himself some of the language growing up, but he soon abandoned it when the practicalities of living, and rough discouragement from the authorities, came about.

The Illutari used to oppress us as long as our people remember, his mother would say. They waged holy wars in the name of their deities and repeatedly held dominion over our hopes and desires. But our gods won; they saw that we were righteous. They will never abandon us, so long as you believe in justice. The way she spoke about this matter felt inexplicably comforting to Rem, who would fall asleep in his mother's arms knowing his world was safe.

His mother, like most menial workers in Port Kitara, began to succumb to years of exhaustion and

substandard living conditions. She told him that the Kangovan gods had a plan for her. She implored him to not take on more work and to just spend time with her, but he could not watch her die. She was also part of a clean-up crew like he was, except she tended to the rich and powerful who were hooked on *Serenity*. She removed their waste, ensured their bodies were pristine, much like hospice care. *Serenity* was initially championed as a way of sustaining the old, terminally ill and dying by freezing their bodies to extremely low core temperatures. However, their minds were allowed to wander in cyberspace, giving them a digital extension to their life. The nobles, bored of earthly life, soon flocked to this promising silicon-based service, and with *afrits* powering the system, they could live out for centuries before their bodies ceased to function. It was to this promised utopia that Rem wanted to send his mother. After endless begging, pleading and getting involved with the wrong kinds of people, he managed to cut an organ donation deal with the black-market entities. They were exploitative and bled him dry—literally—but at least they were upfront. *She deserves that much.*

Through the hardest of trials, you reach the peace of wills, his mother would paraphrase from one of the few ancient texts allowed to the public. He supposed he believed in that, more so because of his mother's spirited proclamations than supernatural promises.

After three long years of all kinds of pain and discomfort, replacing his mother in her job, and the occasional thievery and racketeering, he endured. He stood at the designated meeting place and waited in the shadow of the colossal remnants among the arid plains of their past. Where no flowers bloomed, but darkened green tendrils of thorny vines grew. He heard *afrit*-vehicles approaching before the headlights blinded his vision, and he thought he heard faint wailing before the thruster engines switched off.

"So, here we are then." Honsennar announced.

Rem wanted to ask why they were meeting here instead of their usual rendezvous point in the city, but priorities first. These were pragmatic people who did not take pleasure in theatrics, but he could not wait longer. The *Serenity* subscription for his mother, valid for a hundred years. He needed it.

"I'm ready, I'll just take what I'm owed and be on my way. It is chilly out here." Rem rubbed his arms so as to prove a point and smiled nervously.

A few menacing enforcer types came into view around Honsennar, his supervisor for the better part of his less-than-illustrious career. He ignored them, although his chest felt restless. *They still have my heart! There is nothing to gain from intimidating me; I've already given all that I gathered, and tidbits of information about the nobles too.*

"Freezing even. I know you have questions. And perhaps this might be one form of an answer." Honsennar signalled to someone draped in a weathered cloak. A piercing wail suddenly cut through the precarious atmosphere as an ethereal glow illuminated the air.

Rem's eyes widened. Honsennar slowly continued, a faint smile growing on his face. "It is true that we discovered how to tame *afrits*, but they are far from unintelligent and unfeeling. The way to harvest their energy is through suffering. Doesn't particularly matter whose. Our scriptures tell us we only need frustration, rage and despair. Illutari and Kangovan alike used this to their advantage. *Serenity* might seem like a novel technological invention, but it is a conduit for consciousness from the past that is more than *merely* a virtual world. It is *another* world, one untethered to one's body, and residing in an alternate time. Yet it is in the same *space* as the Kangovan empire. For us to rule that bountiful world, we require power. These blasphemous suckers leech off contracts, signed in blood, forsaking our creators. As such, we are bound by some things we promised you, even if we stand at the precipice of

all that is possible.”

A shocked Rem was led to a monolithic slab of pure obsidian, ancient markings coiling around it. His heart beat faster, almost overheating. He lashed out violently but was easily subdued by the mercenaries. His antics only earned an amused look from Honsennar. "Your body is stressed beyond its natural capacity. There is no point in fighting."

"I still don't understand what you need me for, and what's this elaborate ritual!?" Rem shouted as they bound him to the slab using ropes wrought of material he had never felt before.

Honsennar stopped. "I suppose it can only compound your negativity. So here it is: ever since we began moving organs between people like you and those in *Serenity*, a remarkable phenomenon of confluence came into being. The captive *afrits* thrash wildly and exude twice the power for the same base level of suffering. After combing through our tomes, it appears *afrit-human* hybrids like yourself generate more fuel, unnatural as the union may be. Of course, we'll soon iterate on this 'ritual,' as it were, and make it suitable for mass production. But for now, it must be done in the traditional way: a glass and steel blade through the heart of a suffering heretic. Go on then, curse and call out to the deities you thought watched over you." As Honsennar chanted words he barely recognized, one thing filled Rem's mind—the faith his mother held, even in the darkest of days and melancholic moments. He knew he was far from just, having long since forgotten his prayers. He closed his eyes, willing that the contract would ensure his mother's life continuing in *Serenity*, whatever it may be.

"Ah, one more thing," Honsennar stated mirthlessly, "your mother will go to *Serenity*, but we made no guarantees about her quality of life. A hundred years of suffering. Let that sink in." Primal rage and despair took over Rem. He was convulsing with the weight of emotions, yet what came to mind were the etchings on the toy he found a few days prior, and the hints of a language he learned as a child. It beckoned him, and his *afrit-crystal* heart thumped. The words became clear as an infinite formless being asked him to whisper. So that with each breath, he would remember, and wake from the dream that never was.

"In silence, you are heard. In darkness, you are seen. In emptiness, you are felt."

And Rem awoke in his childhood home to the sounds of his mother singing hymns.



Credit: Proshanto Chanda

Silver Age

By Puyu Wang, DPhil in Engineering Science

I.

In spring 2050 a new file landed on my desk, covered with a stamp in red: DOUBLED. “DOUBLED” means the same event occurred twice. My job is to review these two versions of reality, figure out which is real, and send them to the archive. The real one gets stamped as REAL, the other as SHADOW.

My name is Zhang San, 39, a deduplication officer. My mother thinks I am a civil servant. In a way, I am. Civil servants manage reality. I create the reality for them to manage. My occupation only came into being around 2048. A young occupation like this usually does not pay well, but mine actually does. No one really wants to do this. On average you visit a psychiatrist every three years in this job. I've only been twice, exactly average.

Duplication began around 2046. A Beijing driver delivered the same bowl of soup to the same customer twice. The restaurant owner saw the driver take the soup, but 37 minutes later, the driver showed up, and the soup was still on the counter. He delivered it again. The chef remembered making one bowl of soup. The driver remembered delivering it once. Yet, there were two orders on the platform, two bowls of soup at the customer's door step.

Soon it spread everywhere. An office worker drank the same coffee twice; the cup was cleared, then reappeared with coffee, hot. Police fined the same person twice for speeding, same time, same vehicle and same location. A couple got married twice, at the same venue, with the same guests, just on different dates. Everyone claimed there was only one wedding, however, no one can be certain which one was the one they went to.

At first people assumed it was a data error. It wasn't. Reality had begun to stutter — and a thing could repeat months, even a year, after. The State realized the danger. The laws might break down for it. If a marriage certificate is issued twice, is it one marriage or two? If a crime is committed twice, is it one crime or two? They have to only recognize one. The Calibration and Integrity Agency was founded with three offices: Detection, which finds doubles; Deduplication, mine, which reviews and selects; and Archive. We maintain the archives simply because no one knows what to do with them.

My wife works in Archives. Her job is simple: receive files and seal them. She is not supposed to read them. But she does. Actually, all archivists read. No one can resist not to steal a glance. She does not talk about it. The principle of Agency applies at our house as well — see it but don't say it. But once she broke the rule. It was a snowy winter in Beijing. She came home, sat on the sofa, and mentioned she sealed a wedding. She said, “But in the one version, the father never showed up.”

I asked if that was the real one, she said yes. “...but in the shadow one — one day later than the real one — the father showed up.” After a long silence she continued, “The shadow one is better.” I said nothing. But I didn't sleep well that night.

II.

Deduplication is about being correct rather than better. Our Director Liang never made errors. He is 60 and retiring soon. Every day, 9 AM, he shows up, makes Goji Tea, turns on his computer and looks at

the screen all morning. He continues to look at the screen after lunch, until 6 PM. He approves every report, agrees with every meeting, nods at every SHADOW ruling, "That makes sense." he always says. He is a perfect civil servant who never errs.

But he has mysteries. One winter night I worked until 10PM. Passing his office, I saw the door ajar. Through the gap I saw the room was empty — not just unoccupied but bare. No desk, no chair, no computer, nothing. It was a completely bare empty room. I was shocked but I told myself it was just the light. The next morning, everything was normal, his chair, desk, computer, and himself. "Morning," I said. I cannot say what I saw.

Deputy Director Jiang was a completely different sort of person. He is 44, looking for promotion. He needs achievements, improvements, results. However, at Deduplication, some improvements are not intended—the more shadows we send to the Archive, the more chaos it reveals in reality. That is a mark against stability. The only improvable statistic for him is accuracy. He asks, "Zhang San, made any wrong rulings lately?" I say no, and he leaves disappointed.

III.

Our work on ruling has three principles: how many people remember each version; how many digital traces there are; and the subject's own conviction — which version they would rather believe. These principles form the basis of our induction manual. The manual ends with a small print: 'Where conclusion cannot be made, deduplication officer decides.' Some people call it the conscience clause.

An internal metric, the Ruling Accuracy, is reported to the Central Committee but never made public. It should stand at 100% — once a ruling is stamped, it becomes truth. However, the record shows about eighty-two percent of our REAL rulings are correct; fifteen percent are wrong — we stamped the true one SHADOW and the shadow REAL; and the remaining three percent are undecidable. Eighty-two, fifteen, three, added to exactly one hundred.

Sometimes I think the figures are too clean. Once I said this to my wife. "That's a good thing," she said. "It means someone's maintaining the decimal point." I asked who. She thought for a while and said, "Just someone." Ever since, I've often felt someone is there.

Fifteen percent wrong. That means of the two hundred cases I rule each year, about thirty are wrong. I learned not to be curious about them. But a year ago I had a new colleague, Li Si, who is different. He had a mathematics degree and could get into any department at the Agency. He chose Deduplication because he said he wanted to know what makes things real. I told him that he'd given up knowing the moment he came here.

IV.

Li Si's first case is a man with two identical childhoods. In both there was a classmate, Xiao Fang, whom he never spoke to. Xiao Fang died in a car crash in one version; in the other she went to Shanghai and got married.

The evidence was perfectly balanced. Xiao Fang died. But Xiao Fang is also living. He was stuck for two weeks. I said he had to make a decision now. "But whichever one I pick is real?" he asked. "On what grounds?" I said: "you're a deduplication officer." Eventually he chose "went to Shanghai", and wrote: "maybe the subject could meet Xiao Fang again." Director Liang read the report and clicked "Approve."

Months later Li Si asked me if our work was actually about choosing a more meaningful life. I said, “No, we are choosing a more helpful one.” “Helpful for whom?” he asked. I did not answer. I do not know who needs to be helpful. He then asked, “Who do you think is making this happen?” I said, “I don’t know.” He asked if I would like to know. I told him the conversation was not helpful.

Li Si moved to another department shortly after a year. When I asked Director Liang about it, he said, “I didn’t see it”. My wife asked the same question. “I don’t know,” I said. “Director Liang didn’t see it.”

V.

The case on my desk was from Mr. Wong of Nanjing. He remembered his father died of cancer in 2047 in Nanjing Hospital. Yet later he found a collection of photos showing his father receiving final treatment at Peking Union Hospital in 2048, where he died of the same disease. Only one version should be real. He submitted the case to us.

I asked which he remembered the best. He couldn’t tell. He remembered spending an entire year in Nanjing caring for his father. Yet he also remembered being in Beijing. “Am I going crazy?”

He was not. Both hospitals had complete records, including death certificates bearing the same ID: “104”.

“Which one do you wish to be real?”

“I...don’t know,” he said. “Both are real.”

But I had to choose. I stamped the real 2048 record. It was just closer to him.

VI.

I have never told anyone, not even my wife, about the number 104. I am almost certain I have seen it in another case. But I learned long ago not to be too curious. Then, a few weeks ago, an old man stopped me outside a teahouse. It was just after dusk and I had a long shift. He looks around 60, wearing a Sun Yat-sen suit. He asked me if I was “Comrade Zhang San.” I said I was and asked how I could help.

He answered, “You ruled on my daughter’s case. You thought she went to Shanghai. You were wrong.” I remember the case. It was Li Si’s first. “It wasn’t me, Sir,” I said. “My colleague handled it. You can apply for reassessment.”

“No, it was you. I only wanted to say that you were wrong,” he said. “I don’t need a reassessment.” I tried to explain that his daughter is alive in Shanghai. “She’s not my daughter!” he snapped. “But I just wanted to tell you that you were wrong.”

He shook my hand and walked away. That night I mentioned it to my wife. “Maybe Li Si made a mistake,” I said.

“Who?” she asked.

VII.

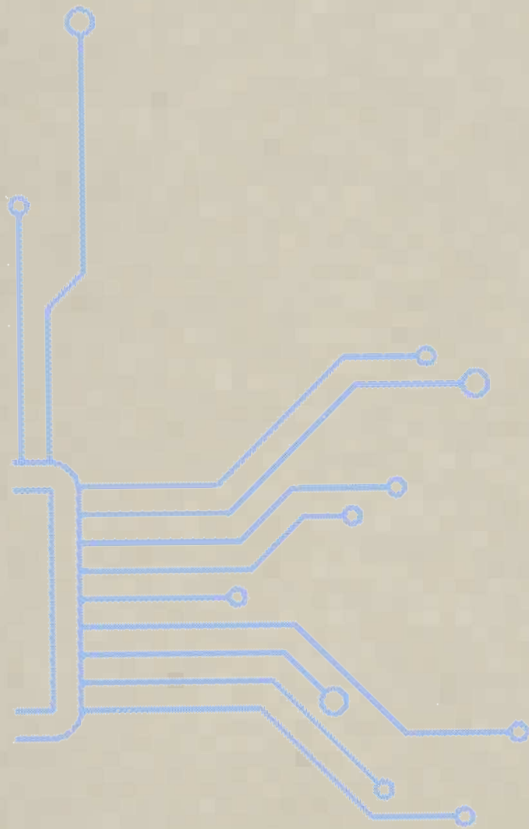
104 feels like a seed lodged in my mind. I just cannot remember where I could have seen it over and over again. The sense of familiarity grew strong.

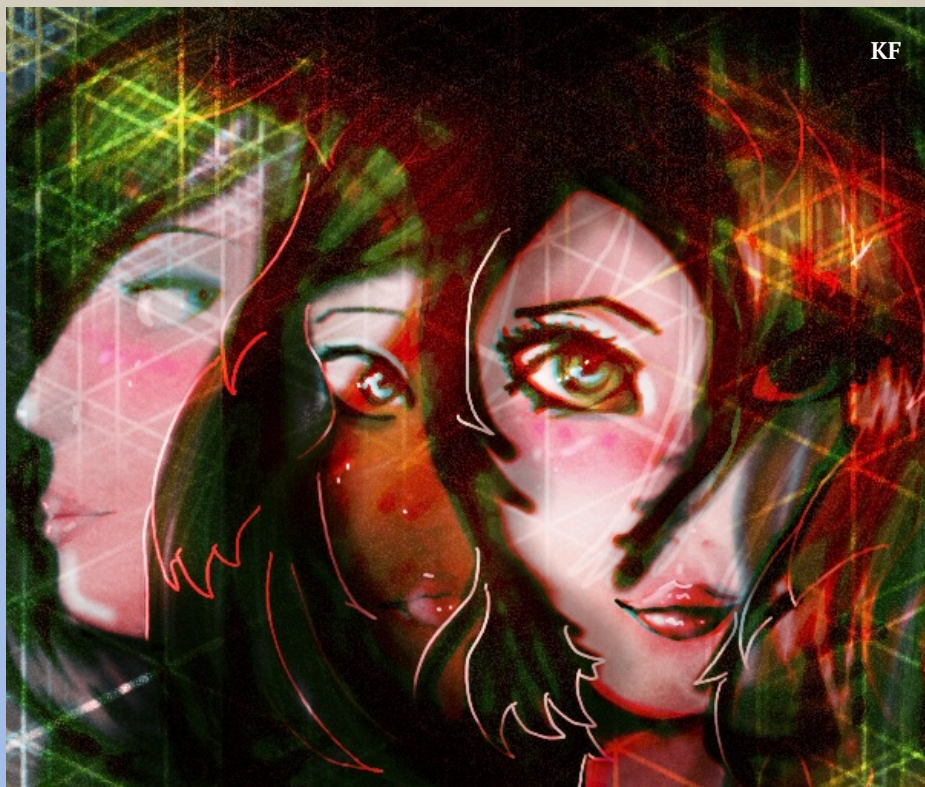
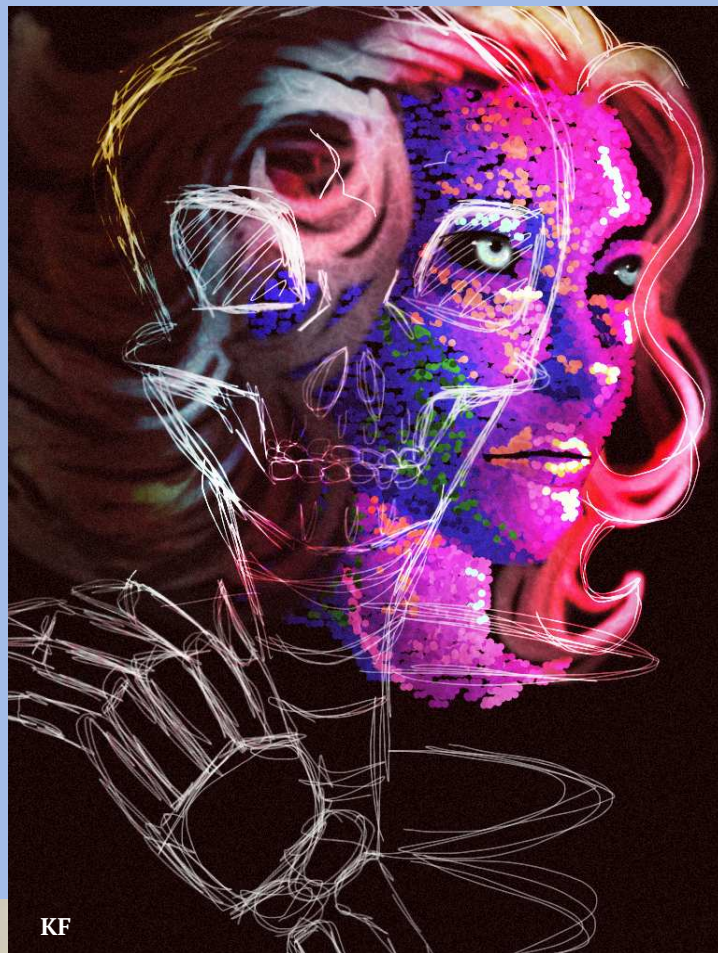
One day a notification appeared on my screen: No. 104 Nanjing – Mr Wong – Request for Reassessment. That moment hit me. I suddenly remembered. It was a few weeks before I joined the Agency. Sitting in a teahouse, I had seen an old man in a Sun Yat-sen suit speaking to a young man outside a teahouse. They shook hands and parted ways. I was at table 104. Then I realized why Director Liang never makes mistakes, why he only approves, and why his office is empty. It is the only useful thing to do. That night I just could not stop thinking about what it all meant. I wonder if I've ever been in notifications. I wonder if I'm helpful.

"Still awake?" My wife murmured. "You should get some sleep." – then she drifted back into dreams. I listened to her breathing in the darkness. Gentle. Steady.

The next morning, she was up before me, cooking congee. It was an ordinary morning. Outside the window, the Beijing sky was a clear blue. "Can you help me with the pancake?" she asked.

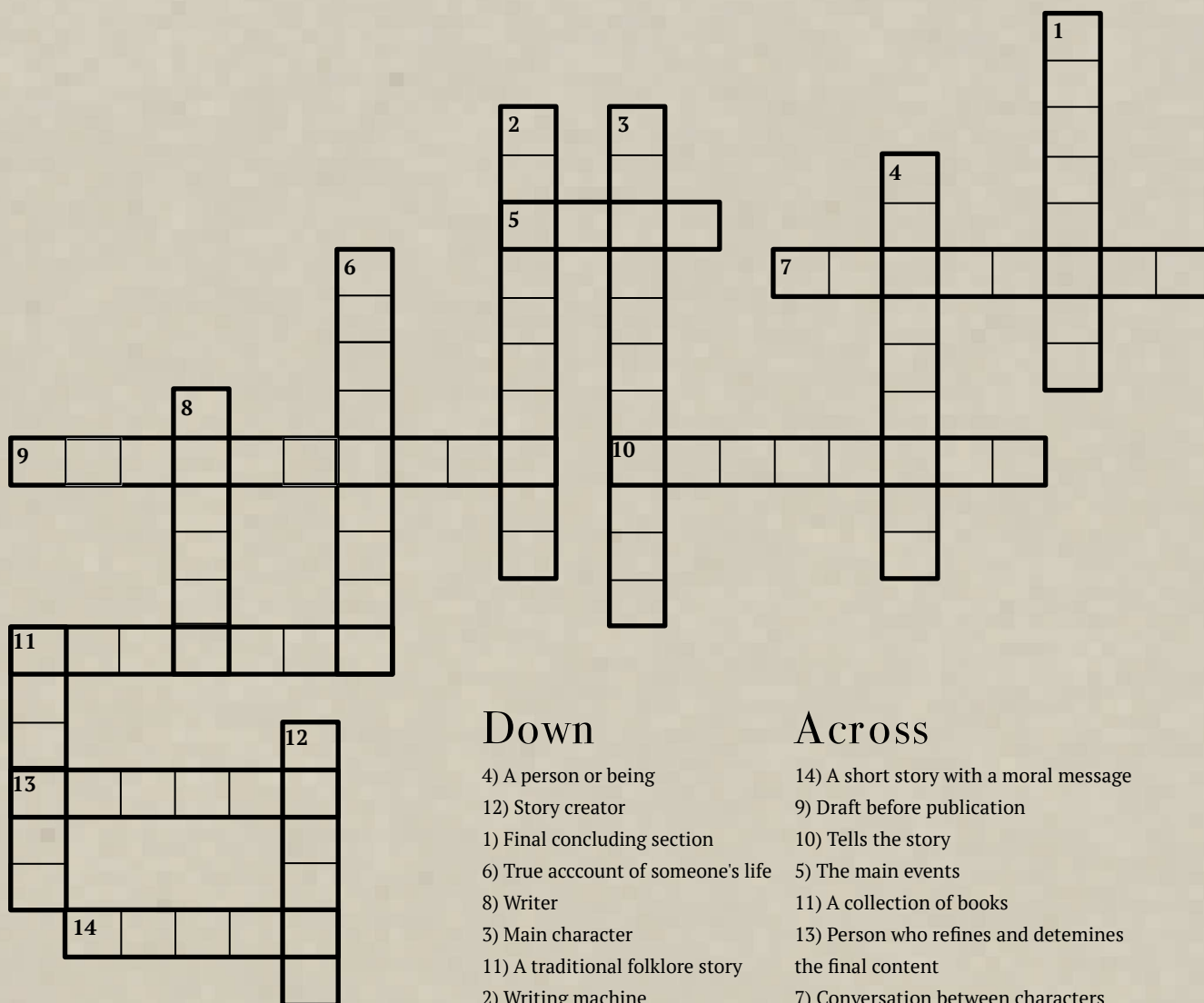
And for that moment, it felt a little real—not because I knew it was real, but because it was ours.





Sophie's Buzzle Pandemonium

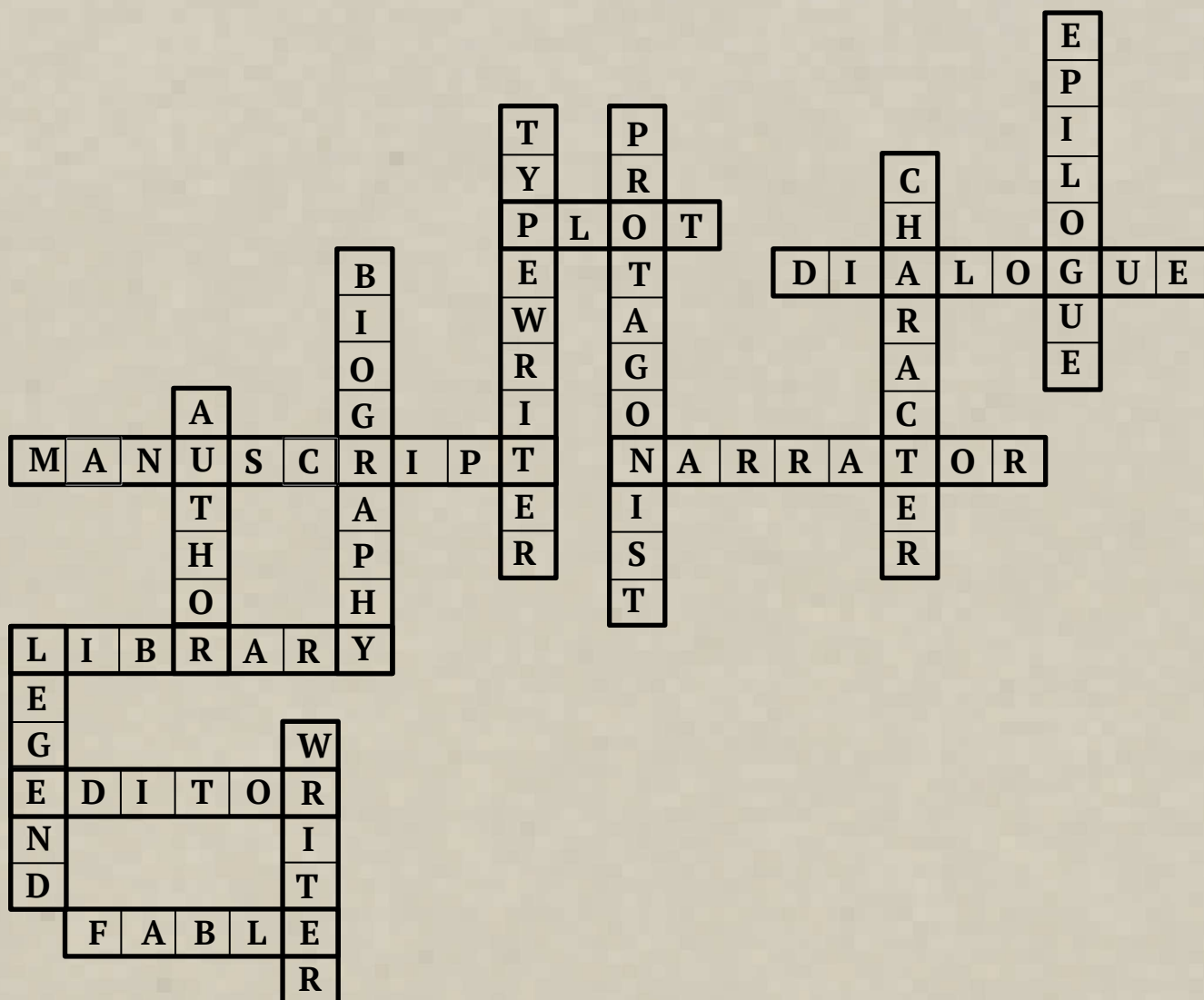
Sophie Brixton, DPhil in Molecular Cell Biology in Health and Disease



Can you find all the words?

P	M	W	C	B	T	C	T	Q	U	O	T	E	U	W	N
H	I	S	T	O	R	Y	Z	H	X	E	F	E	Y	A	F
E	M	R	N	O	V	Q	Z	X	P	O	F	J	Q	D	O
C	G	A	U	K	F	L	N	A	R	R	A	T	I	V	E
P	U	B	L	I	S	H	T	P	I	S	N	Y	G	E	A
K	M	L	T	A	L	E	H	G	E	D	T	A	H	N	F
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J	T	I	I	U	J	O	U	R	N	E	Y	L	C	R	P
O	E	V	L	O	R	E	E	T	Z	D	S	P	T	E	H
H	R	X	L	P	Z	M	B	R	D	V	Y	P	I	N	Z
B	Y	C	E	I	F	H	P	A	N	E	C	D	O	T	E
H	N	T	R	A	V	E	L	R	L	E	Z	Y	N	G	N

Answers



Answers

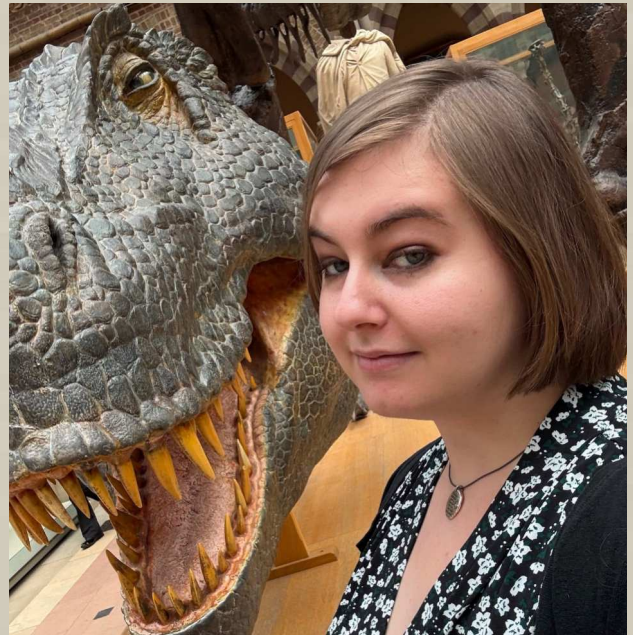
P	M	W	C	B	T	C	T	Q	U	O	T	E	U	W	N
H	I	S	T	O	R	Y	Z	H	X	E	F	E	Y	A	F
E	M	R	N	O	V	Q	Z	X	P	O	F	J	Q	D	O
C	G	A	U	K	F	L	N	A	R	R	A	T	I	V	E
P	U	B	L	I	S	H	T	P	I	S	N	Y	G	E	A
K	M	L	T	A	L	E	H	G	E	D	T	A	H	N	F
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H	R	X	L	P	Z	M	B	R	D	V	Y	P	I	N	Z
B	Y	C	E	I	F	H	P	A	N	E	C	D	O	T	E
H	N	T	R	A	V	E	L	R	L	E	Z	Y	N	G	N

Meet the Team

Katherine Faulkner

Editor in Chief & Visual Artist

Katherine is a DPhil in Environmental Research. A palaeontologist by day, she finds whimsy in the Reuben dinosaur motif. A Reuby-ologist by night, she finds joy in the ingredients that the Reuben Community provides to make *The Reuby* a comforting college soup. She hopes you enjoyed this issue and that you look forward to the many more to come!



Megan Phillips

Senior Editor

Megan is an MSt US History student currently researching the influence of nineteenth-century women's magazines (how appropriate!). While she could have sworn she would never get involved in anything at Reuben, here she is, getting involved. She has greatly enjoyed working on the magazine, but her greatest legacy is changing Reuben's mascot to a dinosaur. Dinosaurs? At Reuben? Groundbreaking.

Daniel Revach

Senior Editor

Daniel is a DPhil student in Experimental Psychology. A member of the first Reuben cohort (a dino indeed), he witnessed *The Reuby* steadily grow in splendour – its editorial team, the quality of its publications, and its role as the voice of the people of Reuben College. Issue 4 continues to embody this very friendship, craft, and vision – in each page and every word.



Prenika Anand

Editor

Prenika Anand is a Reuben Alumnus currently pursuing a PhD in Safety of Artificial Intelligence at the University of York. Her research focuses on the psychological risks of human-AI interactions within assisted living for older adults. She graduated with an MSc in Applied Digital Health from the University of Oxford. Prenika has been a member of *The Reuby* team since 2023, contributing to the Humans of Reuben section since inception.

Proshanto Chanda

Editor

Proshanto is a first year DPhil student in Biomedical Engineering, researching ways to use machine learning to automate medical image analysis. Proshanto previously wrote articles for and ran a personal blog online, but when he realised that this wasn't getting him the romantic attention that he wanted, he decided that criticising and editing other people's writing was far, far easier instead.



Jayroop Ramesh

Editor

Jayroop Ramesh is a final year DPhil candidate in Computer Science and actively researches on automating the radiological workforce. To assuage his guilt of betraying humanity for a marginally financially secure life, he writes and edits for *The Ruby Magazine*.

Jake Neuberger

Average Joe & Graphic Designer

Jake is pursuing an MPhil in Global and Area Studies, following almost four years of collaborating with artists at risk. His research looks to expound on transnational and non-state interactions concerning creativity, memory, mobility, and thought. He chose to join *The Reuby* to uplift student stories, and is proud to have supported this issue's layout and graphic design.



Eliza Rayner

Graphic Design Assistant

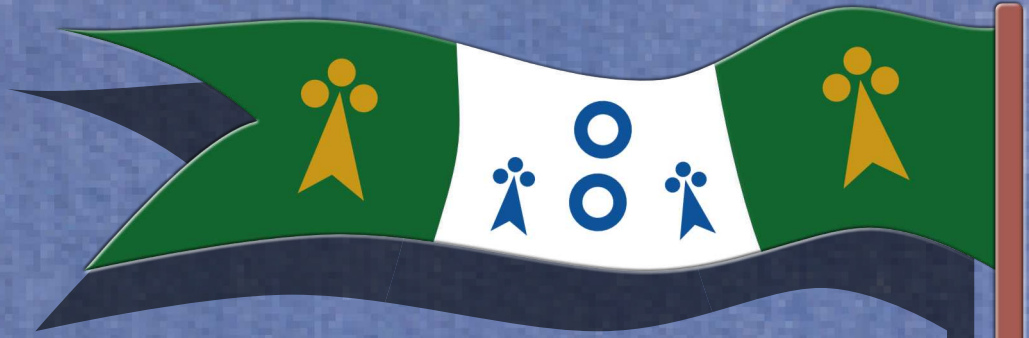
Eliza is a final-year DPhil student in evolutionary microbiology and a member of *The Reuby* team since 2023. Although she intended to focus on writing her thesis this year, the pull of *The Reuby* proved too strong, and she returned to provide some minor assistance with finishing the magazine's layout and design. As she prepares to leave Reuben, she will take very fond memories of her time working on the Reuby!

Puyu Wang

IT Officer & Webmaster

Puyu is another DPhil student at Reuben College who spends much of their time helping computers understand the nuances of human culture. Puyu also maintains *The Reuby* website, <https://the-reuby.github.io/>, where all past issues of *The Reuby*, including this one, can be accessed. Puyu joined *The Reuby* because they believe every individual deserves the opportunity to express their views and be treated as an end in themselves. Also because, quite frankly, *The Reuby* is very cool and full of cool people doing cool things.





FOR QUESTIONS AND SUBMISSIONS,
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OR SCAN:

